

# The Global Burden of Mental Illness: Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global data (World, 2023) • Evidence-based overview for  
public health policy

# Hundreds of Millions Affected: 1 in 3 Women and 1 in 5 Men Face Major Depression



**1 in 3**

Lifetime risk of major depression (women)



**1 in 5**

Lifetime risk of major depression (men)

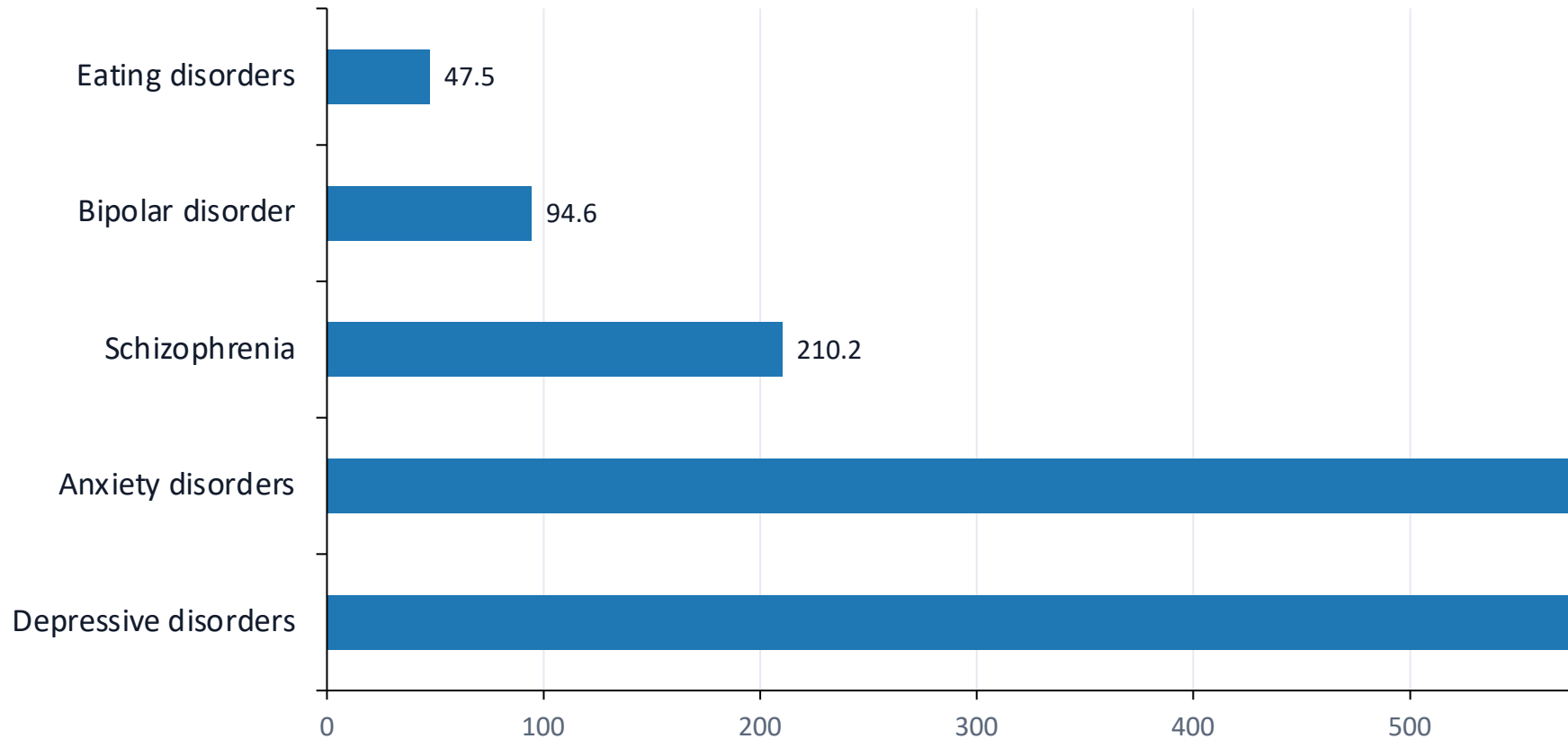
Mental health conditions span a wide range (depression, anxiety) to less common conditions (schizophrenia, bipolar).

Poor mental health affects work, and relationships.

Policy relevance: high population prevalence, persistent barriers to care.

# Depression and Anxiety Dominate: ~695 and ~687 DALYs per 100K Respectively

DALYs per 100,000 people (World, 2023)



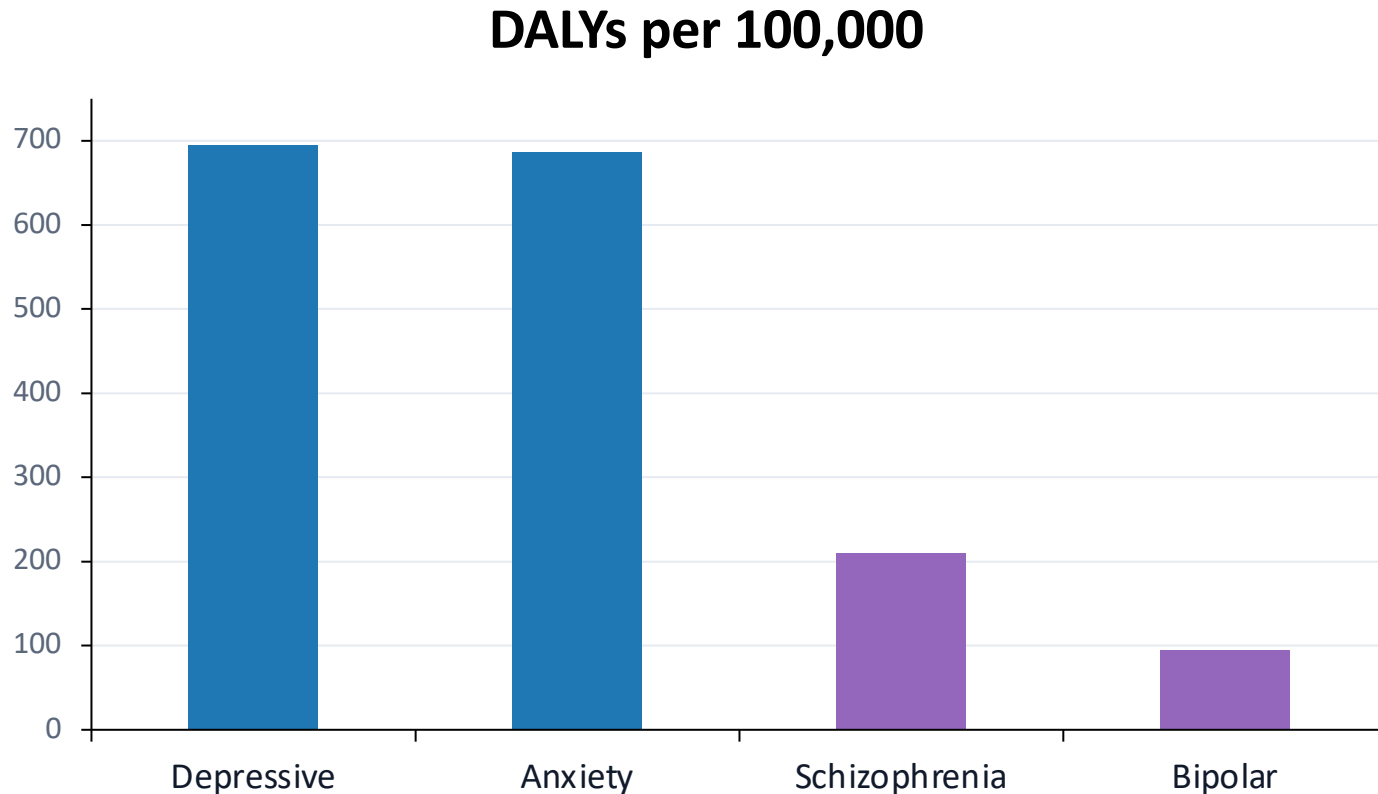
# Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide

**Depressive disorders: 694.6 DALYs per 100,000**

**Anxiety disorders: 686.5 DALYs per 100,000**

Depressive disorders: 694.6 DALYs per 100,000; Anxiety disorders: 686.5 DALYs per 100,000  
Together, depressive + anxiety disorders account for roughly 80% of total burden across

# Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact



Schizophrenia has a lower prevalence per 100,000 compared to depressive and anxiety disorders, despite its severe individual impact. Bipolar disorder also has a lower prevalence per 100,000. Policy implications include the need for specialized care for severe mental health conditions and scaling care for those with lower prevalence but high individual impact.

# Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

## Stigma

Discomfort sharing symptoms

## Access

Treatment often lacking

Care

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced.

Yet many people do not receive adequate care, especially in low- and middle-income countries.

Underreporting (driven by discomfort disclosing symptoms) makes true prevalence hard to estimate.

# How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations

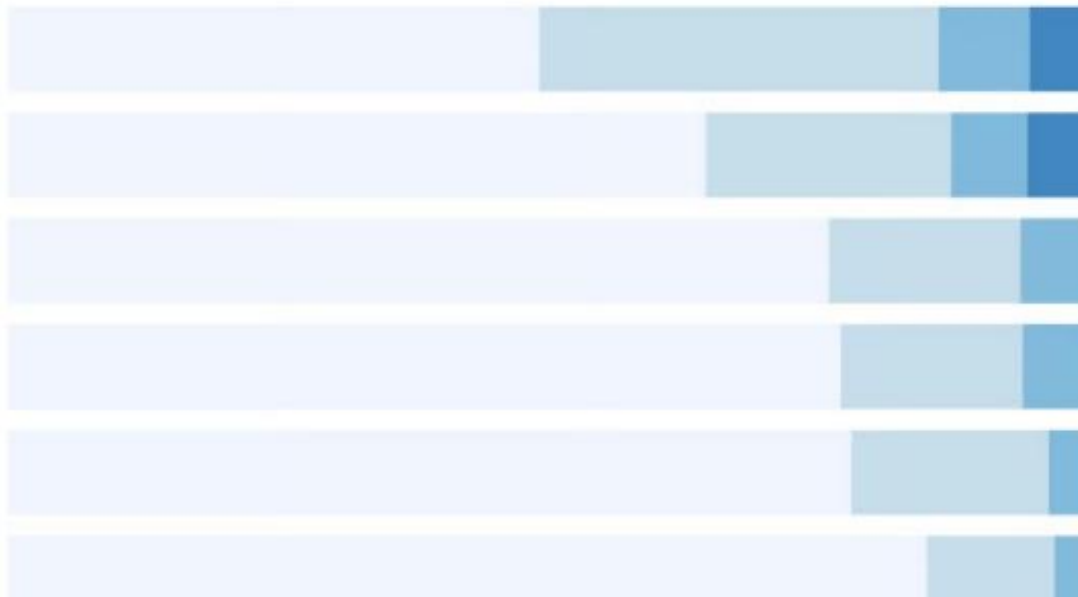
## Prescribed medication

Common in higher-income settings

## Religious/spiritual activities

Prevalent in many regions

Wid



Global surveys show wide  
countries.

Responses are shaped by  
and health-system factors

Policy should avoid one-si  
approaches.

# Key Takeaways: Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

Depression and anxiety represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs across all regions. Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder have lower population-level burden but severe individual impacts. Effective treatments exist, but access and quality remain inadequate. Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data (underreporting). Prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common disorders while maintaining services for severe conditions.